

Session 2: Themes and Foundations of 1 Corinthians

Key Takeaways

- Paul addresses the Corinthian leaders' harmful immaturity and misguided behavior.
- Paul uses a Greek rhetorical structure in 1 Corinthians to make his case and persuade his readers.
- As a letter, 1 Corinthians is only half the conversation, and we must recognize that we can't know everything about the other half.

Themes in 1 Corinthians

There are a number of themes that are woven throughout the letter and keep emerging. Recognizing them first will help us to understand the whole letter.

Holiness

Paul begins his letter by calling the Corinthians holy or sanctified.

1 Corinthians 1:1-3 NRSV*

¹ Paul, called to be an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, and our brother Sosthenes,

² To the church of God that is in Corinth, to those who are sanctified (Greek: *ἡγιασμένοις* / having been sanctified) in Christ Jesus, called to be saints (Greek: *κλητοὶς ἁγίοις* / called holy), together with all those who in every place call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, both their Lord and ours: ³ Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The phrase “having been sanctified” from the Greek word *ἡγιασμένοις* (*hēgiasmenois*), is a perfect participle middle/passive:

- Perfect: an action that is completed in the past with ongoing significance
- Passive: it has been done for them

Holiness is not something we earn or merit. It is given to us. Notice how many times Paul mentions Jesus Christ (four). He's centering the whole letter on Jesus. Holiness is “in Christ Jesus.”

Gifted: The Corinthians Are Gifted

1 Corinthians 1:4-9 NRSV*

⁴ I give thanks to my God always for you because of the grace of God that has been given you in Christ Jesus, ⁵ for in every way you have been enriched (Greek: *ἐπλουτίσθητε* / aorist indicative passive) in him, in

speech and knowledge of every kind—⁶ just as the testimony of Christ has been strengthened among you —⁷ so that you are not lacking in any spiritual gift as you wait for the revealing of our Lord Jesus Christ.⁸ He will also strengthen you to the end, so that you may be blameless (Greek: ἀνεγκλήτους) on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.⁹ God is faithful; by him you were called into the fellowship of his Son, Jesus Christ our Lord.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Division, Factions, and Unity

The process of reading a particular text that was written 2,000 years ago in a language that none of us speak to people who didn't live like us and applying that text to today in our cultural settings requires quite a lot of work!

1 Corinthians 1:10-13 NRSV*

¹⁰ Now I appeal to you, brothers and sisters, by the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that all of you be in agreement and that there be no divisions among you, but that you be united in the same mind and the same purpose.¹¹ For it has been reported to me by Chloe's people that there are quarrels (Greek: ἔριδες) among you, my brothers and sisters.¹² What I mean is that each of you says, "I belong to Paul," or "I belong to Apollos," or "I belong to Cephas," or "I belong to Christ."¹³ Has Christ been divided? Was Paul crucified for you? Or were you baptised in the name of Paul?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Quarrelling and division are extremely serious in Paul's eyes (cf. [Phil. 4:2](#) Euodia and Syntyche whom Paul pleads with to be "of the same mind").

Titus 3:9-11 NIV*

⁹ But avoid foolish controversies and genealogies and arguments (Greek: ἔρεις) and quarrels about the law, because these are unprofitable and useless.¹⁰ Warn a divisive (Greek: αἰρετικὸν) person once, and then warn them a second time. After that, have nothing to do with them.¹¹ You may be sure that such people are warped and sinful; they are self-condemned.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Reversal

Wisdom and Foolishness Reversed

1 Corinthians 1:18-25 NIV*

¹⁸ For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.¹⁹ For it is written:

"I will destroy the wisdom of the wise;
the intelligence of the intelligent I will frustrate."

²⁰ Where is the wise person? Where is the teacher of the law? Where is the philosopher of this age? Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world?²¹ For since in the wisdom of God the world through its wisdom

did not know him, God was pleased through the foolishness of what was preached to save those who believe.²² Jews demand signs and Greeks look for wisdom,²³ but we preach Christ crucified: a stumbling block to Jews and foolishness to Gentiles,²⁴ but to those whom God has called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.²⁵ For the foolishness of God is wiser than human wisdom, and the weakness of God is stronger than human strength.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

See [Isaiah 29:14](#)

- The wisdom of the world equals foolishness.
- The wisdom of God appears as foolishness, but it is wiser than anything in the world.
- The “folly” of God is a higher wisdom than the wisdom of the world.
- The weakness of God is a greater power.

Christ Crucified Is the Key

The wisdom and the power of God center on Christ crucified; Christ crucified is the power of God and the wisdom of God.

Wisdom here refers to the Greek view of wisdom and not the Jewish wisdom tradition. Remember the philosophers, rhetoricians, and orators.

“We should rather suppose, on the contrary, that the acceptance of the Gospel led the Corinthians to feel rich and wise in the possession of new life and spiritual gifts. That feeling was expressed in their calling Christianity a kind of wisdom, its leaders teachers of wisdom, and themselves—this was the most important thing for them—wise men who had drawn on that wisdom through the Christian leaders. The poor, insignificant Corinthians, with neither distinguished ancestry nor pagan wisdom to support them, had become so rich through the new proclamation that they seized on the Greek terminology that was there for them, and used it to express their new glory. They did not realize that by the very use of that wisdom terminology they were betraying the message that was their wealth, and that the feeling of being up on the pinnacle and pitying the others was a betrayal of Christ and his apostles.”

Munck, Johannes (2004). “The Church without Factions: Studies in 1 Corinthians 1–4.” [Christianity at Corinth: The Quest for the Pauline Church](#). Edited by Edward Adams and David G. Horrell. Westminster John Knox. 70.

They were using their Christian experience of the Spirit and their spiritual gifts as signs that they were “wise” and that they knew all mysteries.

Further Themes

- The nature of apostleship and those who follow Jesus, mature versus childish behavior, servants of Christ and stewards of the mystery of God ([1 Cor. 4:1](#))
- Father and mother/child relationship ([1 Cor. 4:14-16](#); [3:2-3a](#))
- All things come from God and will return to him and the God/Christ relation ([1 Cor. 1:30](#); [3:21-23](#))

- The body: what we do with our bodies, our own and others (Food, idols, sexual relations)
- Maturity and *koinonia* (Greek: *κοινωνία* / fellowship/participation)
- Mission and money: freedom and becoming all things to all people
- Spiritual gifts and how we use them
- The centrality of love
- The resurrection: the things of first importance

The Structure as a Conversation

- “Now concerning” (Greek: *Περὶ δὲ*) occurs in 1 Corinthians 7:1, 25; 8:1; 12:1, 16:1, 12.
- “Do you not know” (Greek: *οὐκ οἶδατε*) occurs 10 times.
- “If anyone thinks” (Greek: *εἴ τις δοκεῖ*) occurs 3 times.
- “Judge for yourselves” (Greek: *Ἐν ὑμῖν αὐτοῖς κρίνατε*) is used as a rhetorical question in 1 Corinthians 11:13.

Corinthian “Slogans”

Paul also repeats some of their phrases, but we’re unsure how many there are and where they are.

- “I have the right to do anything.” (1 Cor. 6:12)
- “Food for the stomach and stomach for the food.” (1 Cor. 6:13)
- “It is good for a man not to touch a woman,” or not to have sexual relations with a woman. (1 Cor. 7:1)
- “We all possess knowledge.” (1 Cor. 8:1)
- “I have the right to do anything.” (1 Cor. 10:23)

There might be more!

Organization of the Letter

There is a rhetorical structure to 1 Corinthians in that Paul uses Greek rhetoric (a way of organizing his material) in order to make his case and persuade the Corinthians. We’re not going to study this together, but Ben Witherington demonstrates this really well in his book *Conflict and Community in Corinth*.

We will look at 1 Corinthians from the point of view of what E. Randolph Richards calls “half a conversation,” (Richards, 2004) recognizing that we can’t know everything about the other half.

Richards also talks about preformed material or the use of quoting other material inserted into the letter. Sometimes that’s easily identifiable, like a quote from the Hebrew Bible, for example. Other times, because Paul’s recipients would know what he was talking about and we don’t, we don’t know exactly where he might be using preformed material. “Paul and his coauthors did not always say when they were quoting material. Then, like now, they knew their readers would recognize it.” (Richards, 2004).

“Sometimes Paul told when he was quoting some material, such as ‘for it is written’ (Gal. 3:10) or ‘I handed on to you what I in turn had received’ (1 Cor. 15:3) or ‘the saying is sure’ (1 Tim. 3:1). Paul evidently did not choose to indicate always when he was citing preformed pieces. We are left with the task of distilling them from his letters. So Paul’s use of preformed material falls on a spectrum. On one extreme there are snippets of quoted material that are too elusive to be certain the material was quoted or already integrated into the

team's theology. On the other extreme there are places where the quoted material was introduced by a phrase that clearly identified it as preformed. The challenge is identifying the material between these extremes."

Richards, E. Randolph (2004). [*Paul and First-Century Letter Writing*](#). InterVarsity. 96.

We can use the criteria of content and form when we make the decision about when Paul is citing others.

1. Content: Does the content of the writing tell us?
2. Form: Does the form of the writing tell us?

Interpolation = Insertion

There are also places where scholars think that someone else has inserted something into Paul's letters.

"Interpolation is like pushing a shovel in the ground, separating two portions of soil, inserting something, and removing the shovel; evidence is left, but the breaks are reasonably clean and contained. Redaction, on the other hand, much more closely resembles a plant which has grown in the ground; in pulling it up, the roots come too, and it is unclear where the redaction ends."

Walker Jr., William O. (2001). [*Interpolations in the Pauline Letters*](#). Sheffield Academic Press. 23.

So sometimes we can identify where ideas that are drawn from another source are woven into a text and sometimes we can't.

Paul Was a Skilled Letter Writer

Michael Gorman highlights the skill with which Paul wrote. In his book, *Apostle of the Crucified Lord*, he brings out Paul's great rhetorical skill.

"Paul's letters reveal a thorough acquaintance with the substance and the tricks of the rhetor's trade, even though he formally distances himself from rhetoric, or at least rhetorical showmanship (1 Cor. 2:1-5). ... Paul can either adopt, adapt, or refute certain Stoic notions, depending on his understanding of their correspondence to the Scriptures or to his gospel."

Gorman, Michael J. (2004). [*Apostle of the Crucified Lord*](#). Eerdmans. 7.

"[This is] a bit ironic, since Paul himself has suspicions about rhetoric as antithetical to the power of the gospel, though he is primarily critical of the flashy rhetoric that had become popular in his day and with which certain Corinthian believers were enamored (1 Cor. 1:18-25; 2:1-5)."

Gorman, Michael J. (2004). [*Apostle of the Crucified Lord*](#). Eerdmans. 12.

Diatribes

"One particular rhetorical form that occasionally appears in Paul's letters is the diatribe. Often used by ancient teachers (such as the first-century Stoic Epictetus, in his Discourses), the diatribe did not consist primarily of a lengthy rebuke, as it often does today, but of a creative dialogical mode of instruction and

exhortation. It employs such rhetorical devices as imaginary conversation partners, rhetorical questions, exaggeration, hypothetical objections, and erroneous conclusions. The real speaker refutes the interlocutor's errors (sometimes beginning with the famous phrase, 'May it never be!'), using them as a springboard for teaching."

Gorman, Michael J. (2004). [Apostle of the Crucified Lord](#). Eerdmans. 84.

Acknowledging Our Subjectivity

The Power of Imagination

Everyone brings an imagined scenario to the study! When you read commentaries on the Bible note how many times people say, "I can just imagine ..."

Personal Preference/Bias

My personal preference: There is a Stoicizing influence on the Corinthians but not necessarily on Paul, although Paul is familiar with their thought and language.

Stoicism and Paul

"The question I wish to raise is not whether or not Paul thought in Stoic manner; rather, could it be that he is writing to people who themselves use such language, think in a Stoicizing manner, or are impressed with Stoic ideas? Otherwise why does he so frequently use language that appears Stoic, though he operates with different assumptions? After all, the manner of Paul's expression is not shaped solely by his Jewish background and Christian confession, but surely to some extent by the needs of his audience as well? Do their problems, vocabulary, and level of understanding influence the manner of the apostle's communication with them?"

Paige, Terence (2004). "Stoicism, ἐλευθερία and Community at Corinth." [Christianity at Corinth: The Quest for the Pauline Church](#). Westminster John Knox. 209.

Stoic Ideas in 1 Corinthians

- Pursuit of a spirituality that was elitist and devoid of community-oriented dimension
- The idea of themselves as kings and rich
- The assertion of absolute freedom for the Christian who is *sofos*
- The creed that all things are lawful for me
- The fact that the idol is nothing
- The highly individualistic approach to moral problems (Paige, 2004)

Wisdom and the Stoa

The use of wisdom (Greek: *σοφία*) is a key figure for the Stoa.

“For the Stoa there was a vast gulf between the ‘wise man’ (ὁ σοφός) and the common people (οἱ πολλοί). The σοφός (who is also described as σπουδαῖος, ‘good,’ and φρόνιμος, ‘wise/prudent’) is one who has made the goal of his existence the ‘life in accord with nature’ (κατά φύσιν ζῆν). This is intended to aid the pursuit of virtue, which is the only absolute ‘good’ recognized by the Stoa. Only virtue is necessary to be happy (εὐδαίμων) and wise; all else is ἀδιάφορον (‘indifferent’).”

Paige, Terence (2004). “Stoicism, ἐλευθερία and Community at Corinth.” [Christianity at Corinth: The Quest for the Pauline Church](#). Westminster John Knox. 210-211.

The student must choose that which is according to nature. He needs to intuitively understand “both his own nature and that of the cosmos, and these are in harmony” (Paige, 2004). Paige also makes the point that “the Stoic understanding of virtue is closely tied to knowledge” (Paige, 2004).

The Independent Mindset and the Stoic

“Freedom is one of the most cherished and exalted of attributes of the Stoic wise man: freedom from irrational passions; freedom to choose or reject those things which are in his power; freedom to live the life according to nature and to pursue virtue. But Paul overturns this self-centred perspective by his very life, which in its *imitatio Christi* makes a new definition of freedom.”

Paige, Terence (2004). “Stoicism, ἐλευθερία and Community at Corinth.” [Christianity at Corinth: The Quest for the Pauline Church](#). Westminster John Knox. 217.

Paige suggests that the Corinthians think they are being strong by participating in food sacrificed to idols as if they are almost proving their invulnerability. So Paige calls them an “elite group of self-styled sophoi within the church who held a highly individualistic, self-centred ethics” (Paige, 2004).

But to wrap up this section, we have entered a conversation. We’re trying to untangle different thoughts and words used in different ways by both the Corinthians and Paul and then trying to discern what Paul means by them.

And to complicate things even further, we may be encountering something that Paul taught them in the first place that they have corrupted and twisted to become something else, like wisdom, mystery, glory—all words used in different ways by Paul and the Corinthians.

“Some premises that Paul agrees with—and which he may have asserted himself in his preaching at Corinth—were being made to serve a conclusion at variance with Paul’s theology and, further, at odds with the new existence in Christ.”

Paige, Terence (2004). “Stoicism, ἐλευθερία and Community at Corinth.” [Christianity at Corinth: The Quest for the Pauline Church](#). Westminster John Knox. 215.

“We can make best sense of the text if we imagine the problems to have arisen not among the highest or lowest levels of society, but among those with social pretensions who were most concerned with gaining a greater share of honor and most sensitive to insults which brought shame.”

Pogoloff, Stephen (1992). [Logos and Sophia](#). Scholars Press. 255.

Reflection Question

What are the criteria for determining whether or not Paul is citing others in the text?